

Meta Horizon Creator Competition: Game Design

Game Design Document

Author: Erick Alberto Rea

Game Title: Eight Counts to Midnight

Genre: Simulation & Management

Platform: Mobile, iOS and Android

Orientation: Portrait

Session Target: 5-10 minutes

1. Concept

Eight Counts to Midnight is a gothic romance dance-life sim. The player is a mortal Bachata follower who trains by day, styles herself for the ballroom, restores Crimson Manor, and dances at night with Alistair, a cursed vampire lord.

This is **Simulation & Management first**. The player manages time, stats, cards, wardrobe, rooms, and Bond; the dance is where those choices pay off. Each night is shaped by the player's day choices:

Day Choice	Night Impact
Train Technique	Better starting resources and cleaner footwork.
Rehearse Cards	Stronger choreography options.
Style the Follower	Outfit stats change dance builds.
Improve the Manor	Better rooms unlock better preparation.
Spend Time with Alistair	Bond makes his lead easier to read.

The signature hook is simple:

The first game where deck-construction IS choreography.

Players build short 8-beat Bachata phrases from cards. Footwork and Transition cards fill the count. Styling and Support cards add expression, safety, romance, and score. When the phrase locks, the UI fades and the cards become a cinematic partner dance.

The core fantasy is growth through rhythm and trust. The player starts as a careful outsider in a haunted ballroom. Over time, she becomes a confident partner who can meet Alistair's lead, restore the manor, and bring warmth back to the castle.

2. Target Player

The primary player is a mobile romance, fashion, and cozy-progression player, especially women 18-35, who wants short sessions and visible growth. She enjoys character bonding, style choices, and a clear daily routine.

The secondary player likes light strategy and deck construction. The Bachata phrase system gives that player timing, stance, Flow, and Frame puzzles inside a romantic dance fantasy.

Motivation	How the Game Serves It
Romance and connection	Alistair is the love interest and the lead pattern the player learns to read.
Style with purpose	Outfits change appearance and performance stats.
Tactical expression	Each 8-beat phrase turns card choices into choreography.

3. Core Loop

Prepare by day -> Dance by night -> Grow at dawn -> Return stronger tomorrow

Day: Prepare

Each day gives the player a small number of preparation choices. The player might train Technique, rehearse cards, style the follower, spend time with Alistair, or improve a manor space. The limit creates clear tradeoffs. A player preparing for a demanding lead may train Frame or equip gloves. A player chasing style rewards may rehearse a Close-stance phrase or wear a gown that lowers Styling costs.

Night: Dance

At night, the player performs short 8-beat phrases. Each phrase asks the player to:

- Fill exactly 8 Beats.
- Stay in legal stances. The MVP proves Open and Close; the full game adds Wrap and Shadow.
- Generate Flow through movement.
- Spend Flow on Styling or Support.
- Build Frame for demanding leads.
- Preserve Poise.
- Match Alistair's lead for Connection rewards.

The result is visible right away. Clean choices create a smooth dance replay and a stronger camera moment. Weak choices create a Stumble animation, lower score, and a clear reason to prepare better tomorrow.

Dawn: Grow

Dawn turns the performance into lasting progress. The player earns Lumen Essence, Bond, card materials, wardrobe materials, and facility progress. These rewards improve future day choices and future dances.

Loop Step	Player Question	Payoff
Day	What should I prepare?	Strategic planning.
Night	Can I build a clean phrase?	Tactical dance payoff.
Dawn	What changed because I danced?	Visible growth and tomorrow's hook.

4. Core Systems Snapshot

System	Player Manages	Dance Impact
Day actions	Limited preparation choices.	Sets the resources and tools available at night.
Dance cards	Footwork, transitions, styling, and support.	Builds the exact 8-beat phrase.
Resources	Beats, Flow, Frame, Poise, Bond, and Lumen Essence.	Controls legality, safety, score, and growth.
Stances	Open, Close, Wrap, and Shadow.	Changes which cards, leads, and camera moments are possible.
Wardrobe	Shoes, gloves, gowns, jewelry, hair, and perfume.	Adds stats and helps define a dance build.
Manor rooms	Ballroom, Mirror Hall, Wardrobe Atelier, and Music Room.	Unlocks better training, style, music, and preparation.
Bond	Dialogue, lead study, and matched dances.	Makes Alistair's lead easier to read and unlocks deeper choreography.

The systems stay connected through one question: **what did the player prepare, and how does it change the next dance?**

5. Progression, Depth & Retention

The player grows through connected management layers. Each layer changes both the fantasy and the next dance.

Layer	Managed Through	Why It Matters
Skills	Technique, Musicality, Frame, Styling, Confidence, Connection.	Better resources, safer leads, stronger rewards.
Cards	Rehearsal, upgrades, and deck choices.	More phrase options and cleaner combos.

Layer	Managed Through	Why It Matters
Wardrobe	Gloves, shoes, gowns, jewelry, hairstyles, perfume.	Style becomes both visual identity and build strategy.
Manor	Ballroom, Mirror Hall, Wardrobe Atelier, Music Room.	Rooms unlock training, music, styling, and better preparation.
Bond	Dialogue, lead study, and matched dances.	Alistair's lead becomes clearer and more intimate.

Dance-Card Depth

The card system is built around readable dance verbs:

Card Role	Function
Footwork	Base movement, points, and Flow generation.
Transition	Stance changes that unlock the next move.
Styling	Visual flair, Bond accents, and score bonuses.
Support	Frame, Poise protection, and safer lead response.

Cards and fantasy use the same language. **Step Into Close** changes the partner position and answers a Close Invitation. **Eye Contact** adds Bond when the player matches Alistair's lead. The system feels like dance from rule to replay.

Shadow Stance

Shadow is the vampire-flavor stance. Open and Close teach readable partner dancing. Shadow unlocks through Bond and lets the follower move inside Alistair's supernatural silhouette. It gives high Lumen and unique vampire choreography, but asks for trust and enough Frame. Shadow ties romance, vampire fantasy, and stance management into one rule.

Example Phrase

Alistair's Lead: Close Invitation
Goal: Enter Close before Beat 5

Start Stance: Open

Bar A, Beats 1-4:
Foil Basic Step
Open -> Open
Generates 2 Flow

Bar B, Beats 5-6:
Step Into Close
Open -> Close
Adds 10 Frame

Bar B, Beats 7-8:
Close Sway
Close -> Close

Modifier:
Eye Contact attaches to Close Sway
Costs 1 Flow

Result:
8 Beats complete, lead matched, Perfect Connection x2.
The replay shows the player stepping into Alistair's frame as the camera tightens on Beat 8.

Retention

The return hook is clear: tomorrow the player can dance with more style, trust, and control.

Moment	Player Learns	Next Hook
Minute 1	The manor responds to dance.	Finish the first 8-count.
Minute 15	Preparation affects the dance.	Train for a cleaner partner phrase.
Third session	Builds change outcomes.	Try wardrobe, Bond, and card upgrades.
Later play	The player has a dance identity.	Master advanced leads and Shadow phrases.

First Three Sessions

Session	Player Does	What Changes
Session 1	Completes a Day 1 solo phrase and cracks Alistair's stone shell.	Learns the 8-beat rule and sees the manor respond to dance.
Session 2	Trains Technique, rehearses cards, answers Close Invitation with Step Into Close.	Sees day preparation create a Perfect Connection.
Session 3	Chooses between a wardrobe/stat boost, a card upgrade, or Bond time before dancing again.	Learns that different builds create different replays and rewards.

This early arc proves the full loop in a small space: solo confidence, first partner trust, then player choice.

6. What Makes It Fun

The emotional core is **becoming worthy of the dance**. The player grows through rhythm, trust, posture, and style.

- **Preparation pays off.** Training, rehearsal, Bond, and outfits create better dance results.
- **Small puzzles feel expressive.** An 8-beat phrase is easy to read, but still gives room for style, timing, stance, and support.
- **Romance is mechanical.** Alistair's lead is a character signal and a gameplay challenge. As Bond grows, the player reads him earlier and earns more intimate choreography.

The "one more round" feeling comes from simple goals:

- Land the lead cleanly.
- Train Frame to support the dip.
- Finish an outfit for a better Close-stance build.
- Reach the next Bond level to see a new invitation.

The design is innovative because **deck-construction is choreography**. The player manages confidence, technique, wardrobe, and intimacy, then proves those choices through a danced phrase.

7. If I Had More Time

The first version should prove the daily preparation loop, the 8-beat phrase builder, persistent growth, wardrobe function, and one strong relationship arc. Later versions can expand without changing that base.

Addition	Why It Matters
More songs and rhythm profiles	Gives Musicality more value.
More manor facilities	Adds new training and style paths.
Tornado Camera	A dramatic orbiting reward camera that triggers on high-multiplier phrases, stance chains, and supported dips, turning the best moments into cinematic payoffs.
Levitation and anti-gravity moves	Supernatural Bachata moves unlocked through Shadow and high Bond, where Alistair's power lifts the follower off the floor for partner shapes no mortal dance allows, for example Anita and Varea moves.
Seasonal dance events	Creates themed goals around costumes, songs, and leads.
Deeper wardrobe sets	Builds stronger visual identity and play styles.
Social showcase features	Lets players share outfits, phrase replays, and manor snapshots.
Advanced dance vocabulary	Adds skill after the 8-beat system is clear.
Optional romance routes	Expands the character layer after Alistair's loop works.

The first build stays focused: one partner, one manor, one daily loop, and one clear dance-card engine.